

13. WORLD WAR II(1939-1945)

- The devastation of the Great War had greatly destabilized Europe, and in many respects World War II grew out of issues left unresolved by that earlier conflict.
- In particular, political and economic instability in Germany, and lingering resentment over the harsh terms imposed by the Versailles Treaty, fueled the rise to power of Adolf Hitler and his National Socialist (Nazi) Party.
- After becoming Reich Chancellor in 1933, Hitler swiftly consolidated power, anointing himself Fuhrer (supreme leader) in 1934.
- Obsessed with the idea of the superiority of the “pure” German race, which he called “Aryan,” Hitler believed that war was the only way to gain the necessary “Lebensraum,” or living space, for that race to expand.
- In the mid-1930s, he began the rearmament of Germany, secretly and in violation of the Versailles Treaty. After signing alliances with Italy and Japan against the Soviet Union, Hitler sent troops to occupy Austria in 1938 and the following year annexed Czechoslovakia.
- Hitler’s open aggression went unchecked, as the United States and Soviet Union were concentrated on internal politics at the time, and neither France nor Britain was eager for confrontation.

Outbreak of World War II (1939)

- In late August 1939, Hitler and Soviet leader Joseph Stalin signed the German-Soviet Nonaggression Pact, which incited a frenzy of worry in London and Paris.
- Hitler had long planned an invasion of Poland, a nation to which Great Britain and France had guaranteed military support if it was attacked by Germany.
- The pact with Stalin meant⁹⁷ that Hitler would not face a war on two fronts once he invaded Poland, and would have Soviet assistance in conquering and dividing the nation itself.
- On September 1, 1939, Hitler invaded Poland from the west; two days later, France and Britain declared war on Germany, beginning World War II.
- On September 17, Soviet troops invaded Poland from the east. Under attack from both sides, Poland fell quickly, and by early 1940 Germany and the Soviet Union had divided control over the nation, according to a secret protocol appended to the Nonaggression Pact.
- Stalin’s forces then moved to occupy the Baltic States (Estonia, Latvia and Lithuania) and defeated a resistant Finland in the Russo-Finish War.

The main causes of World War II

- The main causes of World War II was the desire and ability of Adolf Hitler, in control of Nazi Germany to dominate the World and gain control especially of the agrarian resources to the east of Germany.
- He was allied with Japan, which intended to control the much larger nation of China, as well as and several smaller countries.
- Hitler had successfully taken control of Austria and Czechoslovakia by early 1939, when Britain and France reversed their policy of appeasement and switched to a policy of deterrence, warning they would declare war if Germany attacked Poland.
- Hitler thought they were bluffing. He signed an agreement with the Soviet Union in late August that divided up Poland and the Baltic states. Germany invaded Poland on 1 September 1939; Britain and France declared war two days later.
- Key events that led to the war included the 1939 invasion of Poland and the 1937 invasion of the Republic of China by the Empire of Japan. The U.S. entered the war when it was attacked by Japan on 7 December 1941.

Start of the War

- The Second World War must be seen as a continuation of the war of 1914–18.
- The resulting catastrophe – and the false peace that had followed in 1919, in which Germany suffered ignominy and humiliation – had made a further clash between the nations of the West almost inevitable.
- Lenin, Stalin, Mussolini and Hitler triumphed as they did because the First World War led to economic collapse, and the almost total destruction of the middle class in Russia, and its partial destruction in Germany and Italy.
- While communism was entrenching itself in Russia, a rival ideology of fascism was making its appearance¹⁶⁵ in Italy. In 1922, with Italy facing the possibility of civil war, a former school teacher, Benito Mussolini, the leader of Italy's anti-communist, anti-democratic and anti-revolutionary Black Shirts, was charged by King Victor Emmanuel III to form a government.
- In the election of 1924, as conditions deteriorated, fraud, violence and intimidation gave the fascists two-thirds of the total poll.
- Fascism became the official ideology of Italy. Faith in the traditional parties was lost. All those who failed to cooperate with the fascists were removed from office.
- Mussolini's desire to create an empire led to his annexation of Ethiopia in 1936 and Albania in 1939.
- Germany, like Russia and Italy in the postwar period, was ripe for revolution.

- Since 1920, the parties most identified with the republic – the Social Democrats and the Roman Catholic parties – had had severe setbacks at the polls.
- The nationalists and the People's Party on the right, and the Independent Socialists on the left, achieved considerable gains.
- Henceforth, the demands for the overthrow of the Weimar Republic and its leaders became unrestrained. In coalition after coalition, the republic fought to stay alive
- By 1924 Germany was in the grip of hyperinflation. In that year, as leader of the National Socialist German Workers Party, Hitler tried to seize power in Munich.
- Having failed, he went to jail where he wrote his biography *Mein Kampf* (My Struggle), in which he expressed his belief in the purity of the Aryan race his extreme nationalism, his determination to colonize Slav lands and his opposition to democracy in general and the Weimar Republic in particular.
- His subsequent rise might have been avoided if the Genoa Conference of 1922, at which more than 30 nations were represented had not foundered, or if the Locarno treaties, concluded in 1925 between Britain, France Germany, Italy and Belgium, which guaranteed the frontiers of Germany with Belgium and France, had been upheld.
- Forced to choose between what many of them saw as communist inspired chaos on the one hand, and the Nazi promise of law and order on the other, the Germans supported Hitler.
- Not even a demagogue, it was thought, could make matters worse.
- Anarchy and fear had opened the door to despotism. In the election of 1930, as the nation became desperate and the vast army of unemployed grew, the National Socialists (Nazis), embracing the two dominant political ideologies of the age – nationalism and socialism – increased their seats in the Reichstag from 12 to 105.
- The communists also made considerable gains. Nazis and communists fought openly in the streets. In 1932, with the deepening of the world depression, the Nazis became the largest single party.
- On 30 January 1933, as majority leader, Adolf Hitler was appointed Chancellor of Germany by the Reichs president, Paul von Hindenburg
- A system of government by terror and duress, especially against the Jews and the communists, followed.
- In March 1933, using the Reichstag fire as evidence of a communist plot to overthrow the state, Hitler was granted emergency powers for four years; the Reichstag was eliminated as a political force; the Communist Party was

outlawed.

- With the death of Hindenburg in August 1934, the office of Reich's president was abolished.
- Hitler became an absolute dictator, Führer of the German Reich and people. He was to be Germany's undisputed leader for 12 years.
- Once in power, Hitler substituted propaganda and terror for public support.
- The National Socialist German Workers Party was declared the only political party.
- The judicial and administrative systems of the country were concentrated in Nazi hands.
- Everything was sacrificed to the welfare of the party and the security of the state. Racist laws, the 'Nuremberg Laws' (1935) were introduced, excluding Jews from government, the professions and many walks of cultural life.
- At a time when the parliamentary democracies of Europe were under attack, Hitler magnified their weaknesses.
- He became the spokesman of all the anti-democratic, anti-liberal, anti-socialist, anti-Christian, anti-communist, anti-Semitic and anti-Slav movements of Europe.
- In the great purge of 29–30 June 1934, in one fell swoop, Hitler assassinated 77 political opponents for alleged conspiracy. In July, Austria's Chancellor Engelbert Dollfuss was murdered by Austrian Nazis, who attempted an unsuccessful coup.
- Although forbidden by the Treaty of Versailles, efforts had already been made by both Austria and Germany to form a political union. In 1935 Hitler denounced the Versailles Treaty and began rearming.
- The League's attempts to bring about general disarmament were abandoned in 1934.
- The foreign ministers of Britain, France and Italy met at Stresa to protest Hitler's actions, but nothing came of it.
- In 1935 Germany recovered the Saar territory by plebiscite. In 1936 German troops reoccupied the Rhineland.
- In March 1939, Hitler proceeded to annex the whole of Czechoslovakia and the Lithuanian port of Memel.
- Intent now on conquering Poland and regaining the territory given to Poland by the Treaty of Versailles, which divided German West Prussia from East Prussia, he made the 'Pact of Steel' with Italy in May 1939.
- Although in 1934 Germany had signed a nonaggression pact with Poland, in

August 1939 Hitler agreed with Stalin to divide Poland.

- On 1 September, having been warned by Britain and France that an invasion of Poland would bring them into war against him, Hitler attacked Poland.
- Two days later, on 3 September 1939, conscious now that they were in deadly peril, Britain and France declared war against the German Reich. On the same day, Roosevelt, although an isolationist declared that America would stay neutral.
- Roosevelt's actions in supplying Britain with arms, and naval protection in the western Atlantic, were anything but neutral. The day after Japan's attack on the United States fleet at Pearl Harbor, on 7 December 1941, America declared war on Japan.
- Hitler declared war on the United States on the 10th. By 1945 all the nations of Latin America had broken relations with the Axis powers; Brazil sent troops to Europe; Mexico gave air support in the Pacific.
- While Hitler bears major responsibility for the Second World War, he could never have done what he did had he not been faced by weak, divided French and British leaders.
- The democracies' belief that no one could be evil enough to begin a second world war proved false. War followed on a scale such as the world had never seen before.
- In a month (September 1939) Poland was conquered. With Poland occupied by Germany and Russia, Hitler turned west.
- Ignoring the Copenhagen Declaration of Neutrality of July 1938, by means of which the smaller European states (Belgium, Netherlands, Denmark, Norway, Switzerland, Finland and the Baltic states) had hoped to stay out of the forthcoming war, in April 1940 he struck at Denmark and Norway.
- In May he overran Belgium, the Netherlands and France. In a lightning war¹⁰⁵ all these countries fell one after the other.
- In five weeks Germany had overrun Western Europe, Paris had fallen.
- With a reckless determination to win, Germany had defeated a larger Allied force. On 10 June 1940, turning a deaf ear to the appeals of President Roosevelt, Italy attacked France.
- For Britain, the French capitulation on 22 June was the greatest loss. The USSR was preoccupied with Poland and the Baltic states. On 15 July, Hitler offered peace terms to Britain which was rejected.
- Also in July, the US abandoned neutrality by providing the British with 50 destroyers.

- German U-boats in the Atlantic were causing havoc to British shipping. In one week in October 1940 British ships were sunk.
- Meanwhile, with the German Army occupying three-fifths of France, French resistance continued from London and Algiers under General Charles de Gaulle.
- The unoccupied part of France was governed from Vichy as a neutral state gave orders for its invasion in the summer of 1940. The battle for Britain began in the air.
- The German bombing of London and other parts of Britain lasted eight months and accounted for 30,000 dead.
- Defeated by the British air force and unable to penetrate Britain's naval defences, Hitler on 12 October 1940 abandoned the task and prepared to attack the Soviet Union.
- With the invasion of the Soviet Union, the hoped-for colonization by Germans of Slav lands, about which Hitler had written in "*Mein Kampf*", had begun. Hitler's action – however rash it might appear now – was prompted by the fact that Germany had defeated Russia in the First World War.
- Germany's invasion of Russia on an almost 2,000-mile-long front on 22 June 1941 – code name 'Barbarossa' – had been planned since December 1940. Hitler had been talking about it since July of that year.
- The original plan had called for an invasion in May, not June. It was delayed a crucial six weeks because Hitler, in response to an anti-Axis coup in Belgrade in March 1941, had invaded Yugoslavia.
- He had also decided to go to the aid of Mussolini, who now faced almost certain defeat in Albania, Greece and North Africa. Another factor causing postponement was the unusually heavy spring floods which hindered movement across the Polish–Russian river areas.
- The decision to go to Mussolini's aid opened a chapter of disasters, which played no small part in Germany's ultimate defeat in 1945.
- In an effort to reinforce the imperiled Italian Army in Albania and Greece, the Germans were compelled to fight a prolonged and difficult campaign in Yugoslavia. Having rescued the Italians in Albania and Greece, the Germans then fought the British in Crete.
- From Crete they then went the aid of the Italians, who by now were being driven from Libya by the British, Australians and New Zealanders. Under General Erwin Rommel, the German Africa Corps was formed.
- Step by step, largely on Italy's account, Germany found itself committed to war in the Mediterranean and the Middle East. Without any overall, long-term strategy,

the Germans seemed fated to overreach themselves.

- When, at last, the main German Army was unleashed against Russia in June 1941, it was already too late.
- In June 1941, taking advantage of Germany's assault upon the Soviet Union, Japan began its expansion in Southeast Asia.
- Having overrun French Indo-China, it attacked the Americans in Hawaii and in the Philippines, the British in Hong Kong, Malaya and Burma, the Dutch in Indonesia and the Australians in New Guinea.
- By May–June 1942, with lightning speed, the furthestmost point of their expansion had been reached. With Germany's invasion of Russia in June 1941 and Japan's attack on Pearl Harbor, the war became global. These two actions sealed the fate of the Axis powers.
- The Japanese attack ensured that the Americans would enter the war with their enormous industrial potential. Britain had been receiving equipment and supplies from America since the passing of the US Lend-Lease Act in March 1941.
- Germany's declaration of war against the US also assured that American priorities would be settled in favour of the Atlantic rather than the Pacific.
- The attack on Russia committed Germany to a prolonged, limitless war – the largest military campaign there had ever been – which, with all its other military adventures, it could hardly hope to win.
- The odds against it in manpower armor and aircraft were formidable. Enormous supplies of weapons reached Russia from Britain and America.
- It was on the eastern front that Germany lost the war yet at the outset the Germans could not have done better.
- By November they had ¹⁰⁵overrun the Baltic States and the Ukraine and were outside Leningrad and Moscow. Millions of Russian soldiers were captured.
- The reaction in Britain and the US to the Nazi invasion was one of relief; the threatened German attack on the British Isles had been postponed.
- The feeling of relief soon turned to one of fear as the German Army swept all before it.
- The West became concerned that the Russians would be defeated, leaving Germany free to deal with Britain alone.
- In 1942 Germany's armies still stood outside Moscow and Leningrad in Russia, and in Alexandria in Egypt.
- At El Alamein Rommel's army were only a few miles from the Suez Canal, Britain's lifeline to the East.

- Control of the Mediterranean and Britain's vital oil supplies were both in peril. Oil was Germany's greatest need.
- Until 1942 the Axis Powers' chances of winning the war still looked good.
- By May 1943 the Allies had defeated the German Army in Africa and had invaded Sicily and Italy.
- In July 1943 Mussolini, having suffered defeat in east and North Africa, fell from power.
- By June 1944 Rome had been taken and Italy had switched sides and had declared war on its ally, Germany.
- With the failure of the German offensive at Kursk-Orel in July 1943 initiative on the eastern front was taken out of German hands.
- By 1944 the Soviets had repossessed the Ukraine, broken the German siege of Leningrad and moved into the Baltic States.
- The long-awaited D-Day, agreed upon at the Allied conference at Teheran in 1943, had arrived. Overnight, the resistance movements of German-occupied Europe came out into the open.
- Germany was now besieged from the east, the west and the south. Paris was liberated by the end of August 1944.
- By March 1945 Allied armies had crossed the Rhine. Nor was Germany able to stem the invasion by the use of its newly developed guided missiles. Instead, the horror of war began to spread across Germany.
- The German attempt to recover the initiative in the west – by striking through the Ardennes in the autumn of 1944 (the Battle of the Bulge) – failed, as the Spring offensive had failed in 1918. In the east, in January 1945, Warsaw fell; in April, Soviet troops reached Berlin. Hungary, Romania and Bulgaria had already been overrun. On 25 April 1945, the Allied and Russian forces met on the Elbe.
- On 30 April, in a bunker in Berlin, Hitler committed suicide.
- Mussolini had already been shot by Italian partisans; with his mistress he was hung by the heels by a bloodthirsty mob in Milan.
- On 7 May the Germans surrendered unconditionally.
- The war in Europe was over. It remained to defeat the Japanese, who in a series of brilliant campaigns had overrun the British, French and Dutch empires in Southeast Asia and had reached India, New Guinea and Guadalcanal.
- By the spring of 1942 the last US stronghold in the Philippines had fallen, much of Southeast Asia and the western Pacific was in Japanese hands.
- The turning points were the decisive defeats of the Japanese at the naval battles of the Coral Sea (May 1942) and Midway (June 1942).

➤ In August, Allied forces under General Douglas MacArthur attacked Japanese positions in the Solomons.

➤ In September Japanese ground forces were defeated by the Australians on the Kokoda Trail in New Guinea, and in the spring of 1944 by the British and the Indians at Imphal on the border of India.

➤ By October 1944 the Americans had island-hopped across the Pacific and had retaken the Philippines. With the battle for Leyte Gulf, the greatest battle of its kind in history, the threat of the Japanese Navy was ended.

➤ The subsequent capture of Iwo Jima and Okinawa in March–April 1945 provided a base from which Japan could easily be bombed.

➤ Until August 1945 the skies above Japan were rarely free of land-based and carrier-based American aircraft. US submarines blockaded Japan.

➤ On 16 July the US detonated its first atomic bomb at Los Alamos in New Mexico. On 6 August an atomic bomb was dropped on Hiroshima and on 9 August on Nagasaki.

➤ One of the most powerful considerations in dropping the bomb was to end the war before the Soviets could stake a claim for the joint occupation of Japan.

➤ Had not President Harry Truman and General MacArthur resisted Soviet proposals, Japan, like Germany, would have become a divided state. On 8 August, ignoring its nonaggression pact with Japan, the Soviets attacked Japanese positions in Manchuria. Japanese resistance collapsed.

➤ With Japan's acceptance of the Allied terms of capitulation on 14 August, the war in the East was over. In allowing their ambitions to run wild, the Japanese had become committed to undertakings far greater than their strength could support.

➤ The Second World War is the first war in history where the civilian losses outnumbered those of the military. ¹⁰⁵

➤ It was a turning point in the history of warfare. Germany and Japan emerged from the war at the mercy of the Allies. Japan was stripped of the Pacific islands it had acquired before 1941, and of all possessions seized since 1941.

➤ The Soviet Union annexed the Kurile Islands north of Hokkaido; the US took Okinawa (the Ryukyu Islands) and obtained a trusteeship of the Pacific islands formerly mandated to Japan – the Mariana, Caroline and Marshall Islands.

➤ The trial of Japanese and German war criminals followed. The Axis Powers had been warned by Churchill and Roosevelt that they would be held responsible, and they were.

➤ Power abhorring a vacuum, in 1945 the US and the USSR emerged as the two greatest world powers. Although three of the five great powers of the time – the US, the

USSR, Britain, France and China – were European powers, the Eurocentric world system, which had prevailed since the sixteenth century, was at an end.

- A bipolar world replaced the multipolar world of nineteenth-century geopolitics.
- The concessions made to Stalin at Teheran (1943), Yalta and Potsdam (1945), which gave Russia parts of Germany and Poland, and gave Poland parts of Germany and divided Germany itself, had greatly enlarged Russian tutelage in eastern and central Europe. Despite what Hitler intended, for the first time in its history, central and Eastern Europe were at the mercy of the Russians.
- By 1948, except for Greece, Turkey and Yugoslavia, Eastern Europe had come under Soviet control. By then communist power had been established in Poland, East Germany, the Baltic States (except Finland), Romania, Yugoslavia, Hungary, Bulgaria and Albania.
- Except in Albania, Soviet power was never extended without military pressure. Also in 1948, in order to keep its outer defences intact, the Soviets seized power in Czechoslovakia.
- One of the astonishing outcomes of the war was the way communist Russia was able to reach out and seize control of so much of Europe.
- In 1939, Britain and France had gone to war because Hitler had invaded Poland, whose independence they had guaranteed. Russia's invasions, which began with the conquest of eastern Poland and ended with the seizing of Czechoslovakia, raised no such furor in the West.
- Similarly, the atrocities committed by the Soviets in their rapid expansion in Europe have been glossed over.
- The West seems to have had a double standard: one by which to judge the diabolical actions of Hitler; the other by which to judge the conduct of 'Uncle Joe' (Stalin).
- Hitler's invasion of Poland meant war; Stalin's invasion of Poland meant that he became an ally of the West.
- Russian attitudes towards the West at the end of the Second World War are partly to be explained by Russia's severe losses.
- The 'marriage of convenience' of the war years between capitalism and communism had ended. More importantly, from 1939 to 1948, nobody had the will or the power to halt Soviet transgressions. Regardless of America's superlative economic and military power, it had no desire to challenge Stalin's policy of imposing the communist system as far as the Red Army could reach.